Our counterinsurgency operations and the Kargil war remain the finest examples of heroic deeds by junior leadership, who defied adversity, terrain, altitude, snow-bound jagged peaks at 18000-20,000 feet and above; officers and men who displayed unbelievable leadership qualities and courage under fire … and whose spirit echoes even today in the hills of Tololing, Dras, Batalik and Tiger Hill – a haunting warrior's credo immortalized in the words: 'Yeh dil mange more.'

The officers of the Indian Army have always led by example and from the front, and this is a sacred trust that you have imbibed from the collective consciousness of the valour of the Indian Army. A trust that translates into a saga of our officers' casualty ratio vis-à-vis the soldiers being the highest ever recorded in past campaigns the world over. A trust which commits the men you command to walk through a hail of bullets, which may take the soldier's life but never his spirit and sacrifice, a spirit which will always unfurl the national flag atop the peaks of victory. This telling tale of the power of flag was evocatively voiced two centuries back by Sir Edward B. Hamley:

> *A moth-eaten rag on a worm-eaten pole*
> *it does not look likely to stir a man's soul,*
> *'Tis the deeds that were done 'neath the moth-eaten rag,*
> *When the pole was a staff and the rag was a flag.*

I would like to share with you that I believe in the creed of a 'warrior and winner'. Live life with the determination that we will win; for me it has always meant 'Fight to Win'. And in fighting to win, in boxing, wrestling or other sports and even in battle, you can either win by points or you win by knockout. I would prefer that we succeed against every challenge by a knockout. Remember, there is no prize for the runner-up in war; it is tragic but true in life that the winner takes it all. Further, in real life and in war, I am of the conviction that the underdog is not the right situation to be in. We should always be the top dog. And therefore, my motto has been